

Safe Motherhood

A healthy pregnancy and a safe birth protect both mother and baby. Start antenatal care early, plan for the birth, and know the danger signs.

For community members

Key messages

- As soon as you think you may be pregnant, go to the health centre. Signs are a missed period, bigger breasts, feeling sick in the morning, passing urine often, and a growing belly.
- Go for at least four antenatal care (ANC) visits. Each visit checks you and your baby, and gives you iron and folic acid tablets, tetanus injections, malaria medicine and a bed net.
- Ask to be tested for HIV and syphilis at your first visit. Testing early protects your baby.

- Make a birth plan with your family: where you will give birth, how you will get there, who will go with you, and what to take. Save money for transport. Keep your Helt Buk Bilong Ol Meri safe. It shows your due date, about 40 weeks after your last period.
- Plan to give birth at the health facility with a trained health worker.
- Eat a variety of foods, drink clean water, wash your hands, rest, and sleep under a treated mosquito net every night.
- After the birth, you and your baby need check-ups at the health centre on day 1, 3, 7 and 14, and at 6 weeks.
- Breastfeed your baby as soon as possible after birth, within the first 90 minutes. Give only breast milk for the first six months.

Go to the health centre straight away if you have

- Any bleeding from the vagina
- A very bad headache, blurred vision or fits
- Fever, or feeling very hot (it could be malaria)
- The baby moving much less, or not at all
- Severe pain in the belly, or burning pain when you pass urine
- Strong pains that come and go, before your due date
- Vomiting that will not stop late in pregnancy
- After the birth: heavy bleeding, fever, smelly fluid from the vagina, or belly pain

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.